

YIHAN ZHAO

Shenzhen, China | zhaoyihan@cuhk.edu.cn | [Personal Website](#)

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Early Social Development: Parent-child interaction · Social motivation

Autism Research: Early identification and intervention · Family-centered support

Family Processes: Coparenting · Parent-child relationships · Transition to parenthood · Family systems

Technology-Mediated Assessment & Intervention: Child-AI/Robot interaction · Serious games · Telehealth

EDUCATION

Master of Social Sciences in Counselling

Sep 2024 - Oct 2025

City University of Hong Kong | Hong Kong

- GPA: 3.40 | Top 10%

B.S. in Psychology (Biology)

Aug 2019 - Dec 2021

University of California, Davis | Davis, CA, USA

- GPA: 3.40 | Dean's List, 2020-2021

PUBLICATIONS, PRESENTATIONS & WORKS IN PROGRESS

Zhao, Y., Zhang, L., Li, K., Ke, S., Lu, S., & Zeng, G. (2026). *The gift of the tenth month: Early design of a partner-inclusive prenatal education serious game*. Companion Proceedings of the Annual Symposium on Computer-Human Interaction in Play (CHI PLAY Companion '26). ACM. (Accepted, forthcoming).

Li, K., Chen, Y., Zhao, Y., & Zeng, G. (2026). *Computational modeling of facial trustworthiness perception on action units using machine learning*. [Oral presentation]. 14th Conference for Chinese Psychologists.

Zhang, L., Lu, S., Zhao, Y., & Zeng, G. (2026). *Assessing social understanding in vision-language models using physically-grounded abstract social event animations*. [Poster presentation]. 14th Conference for Chinese Psychologists.

Zhao, Y., & Zeng, G. (2026). *From computational estimates to human judgments: A lens model account of perceived openness*. (Manuscript in preparation for submission).

Zhao, Y., & Zeng, G. (2026). *Toddlers' visual attention to social interactions varies across physical contexts*. (Abstract in preparation for submission to the 2027 Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting).

Zhao, Y. (2026). *Recalled parenting styles and interpersonal skills in Chinese young adults: EI mediation and gender moderation*. (Master's thesis, in revision).

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Lab Manager / Research Assistant, SEED Lab

Jun 2025 - Present

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen | PI: Prof. Guangyu Zeng

- Manage ongoing research with approximately 100 families of infants aged 5–24 months, including family follow-up, scheduling of ~230 experimental visits, parent-child interaction sessions, eye-tracking data collection and analysis, and RA scheduling.
- Design and lead nature-based outdoor activities for approximately 50 families with children aged 2–5 years, and coordinate and adjust team assignments.
- Develop and refine study protocols and IRB materials and help translate ongoing projects into research outputs including conference abstracts, posters, and manuscript drafts.
- Completed SCS training and qualified as a reliable coder for recorded parent-child interactions; train and coordinate 15+ graduate and undergraduate RAs across participant procedures, data collection, and study protocols.

Research Assistant, TEPE (Tracing Effective Preschool Education) Project

Nov 2024 - Jan 2025; Apr 2025 - Jun 2025

The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen | PI: Prof. Runke Huang

- Led a fieldwork team for developmental data collection across 44 kindergartens in Shenzhen, coordinating researcher schedules, assessment materials, site visits, and study records.
- Administered IDELA assessments with preschool children and improved the paper-based workflow for data collection, recording, and verification to make fieldwork and data handling more efficient.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Direct Support Professional

Apr 2022 - May 2023

Summer House Inc., | Davis, CA, USA

- Provided individualized support to 12 adults with intellectual and developmental disabilities, including daily living, community participation, communication, and social interaction.
- Worked directly with residents and their support teams to implement individualized routines and behavioral support plans.

RESEARCH & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Research Methods: Eye-tracking data collection and analysis · EEG data collection · fNIRS data collection

Technical Tools: R / RStudio · SPSS · Tobii Pro Lab · ELAN · BORIS · Godot Engine 4

Languages: Mandarin Chinese (Native) · English (Professional) · Cantonese (Basic)